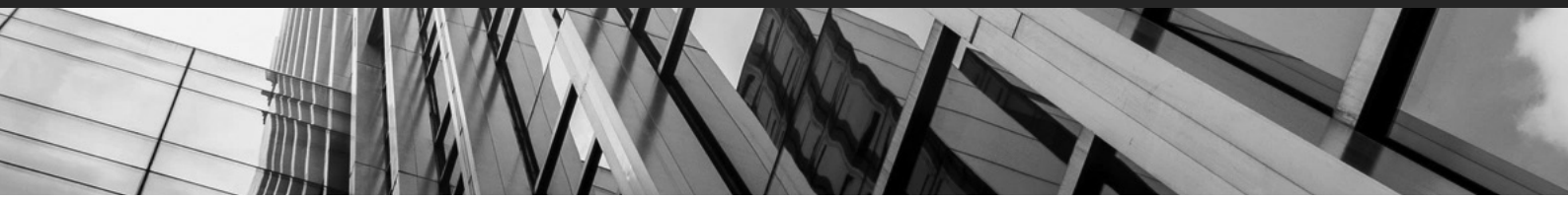


naf newamerican™ FUNDING

New American Funding Leverages Polly to Unlock Flexibility and Scalability to Boost Borrower-centricity and Thrive in a Challenging Market

/ COMPANY PROFILE

Headquartered in California and operating in 190 locations throughout the United States, New American Funding (NAF) is an independent mortgage lender with a servicing portfolio of 250,000 loans worth more than $65 billion.

A multi-channel lender, NAF's expansive product portfolio includes conventional, FHA, VA, USDA, jumbo, and refinance loans. In addition, it offers a variety of specialty loan products, such as construction, renovation, property investment, and down payment assistance, as well as a reverse mortgage division. The company also boasts several growing affiliates, NAF Homes (an agent referral firm) and NAF Cash (providing cash offer services).

New American Funding is one of the largest independently held mortgage banks and the largest Latina-owned lender. Since its inception two decades ago, it has enabled thousands of underserved borrowers to accomplish the American dream of homeownership. As part of its commitment to underserved communities, NAF launched the Latino Focus project in 2013 to address Hispanic consumers' lending challenges. Building on this success, it created the NAF Dream initiative in 2016 to raise awareness and increase homeownership in Black communities.

NAF's focus on diversity and inclusion goes beyond its borrowers, with a 55% female and 43% minority workforce. The company offers state-of-the-art career training and provides branch LOs with innovative technologies to streamline the mortgage process. The company also took an impressive rank on the Fortune 100 Best Companies to Work For® in 2023.

/ OVERVIEW

New American Funding approached Polly at a crucial point in its business trajectory. Having outgrown its previous PPE, it needed a more flexible, scalable, and sophisticated solution compatible with a new strategic direction and future growth ambitions. However, NAF did not want to invest considerable time and resources into building a proprietary tool from scratch.

Senior executives faced a stark choice: Completely reimplement NAF's existing PPE or procure a modern platform. After a careful evaluation, NAF decided to replace its legacy engine with Polly's cloud-native, high-performance PPE, citing the scalability and configurability of the platform and Polly's hands-on approach to customer success as its key motivators.

NAF signed with Polly in December 2022 and kickstarted the PPE implementation process the following month. The integration launched in April 2023, and the company adopted a staggered approach to its deployment to ensure success across its team. Following implementation, NAF executives have continued to collaborate closely with Polly's executive and dedicated support teams on initiatives related to its unique strategies.

/ RESULTS

- **Make strategic shifts to thrive in a difficult market environment:** Polly's Product and Pricing Engine (PPE) granted NAF near-infinite configurability, flexibility, and scalability to support its expansive product suite's many pricing and product structures. As a sales-focused business, this enabled NAF to shift its strategy to develop new, non-traditional mortgage products, flexing up and down with market shifts.

- **Deliver the best possible borrower experience:** With Polly's PPE, NAF has created a 'single universe' where LOs can access its entire product offering. This enables them to match borrowers with the best possible product every time.

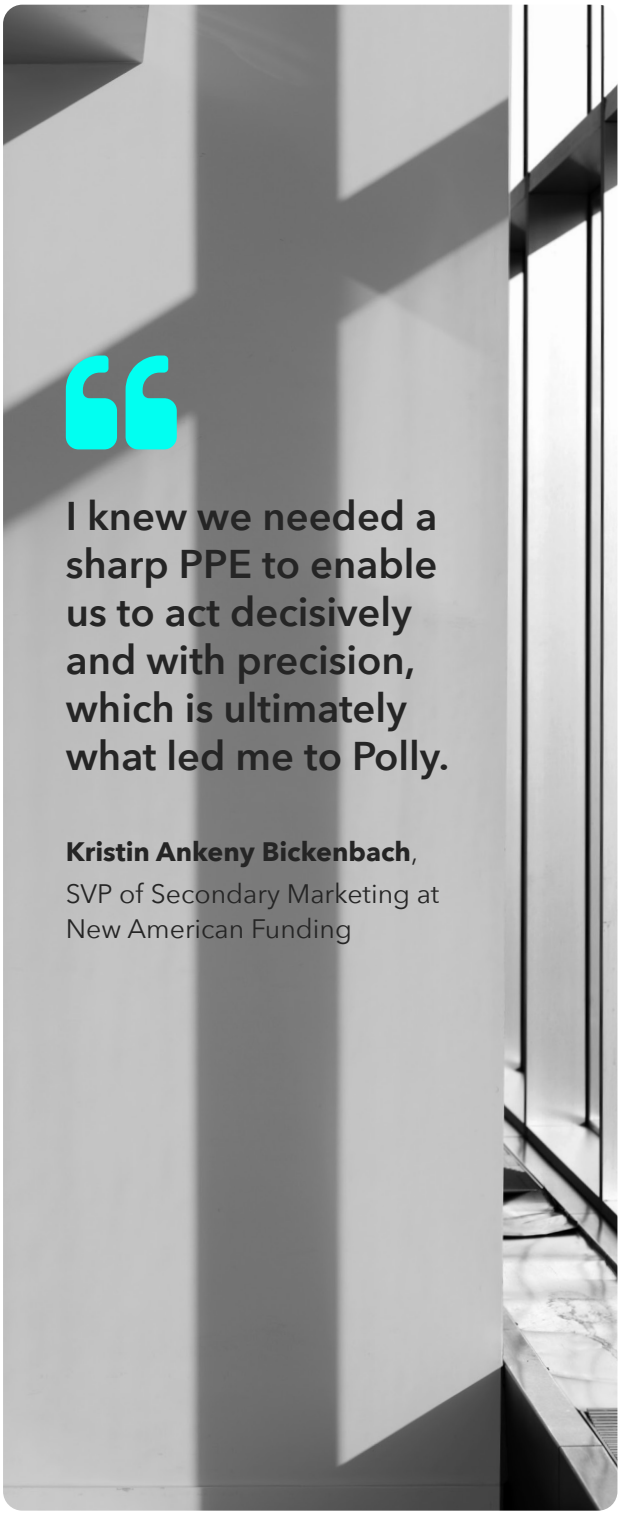
- **Save LO time and enhance retention:** Polly's PPE boasts a modern architecture and a clean, intuitive user interface. NAF's LOs quickly recognized the platform's benefits, notably its high levels of automation, after receiving hands-on training from the Polly team.

/ THE DETAILS

Moving beyond a 'cookie cutter' approach to support future growth

New American Funding boasts an expansive product suite. This continues to grow rapidly in today's challenging mortgage market, as the company focuses on developing non-traditional mortgage products and building proprietary products for second liens, HELOCs, closed-end second mortgages, and more. This requires substantial personalization, which NAF's previous PPE struggled to achieve due to architecture limitations. Using modern cloud technologies and a high-performance infrastructure, Polly's PPE is able to deliver the most advanced security, near-infinite scalability, and access to the most sophisticated data science and machine learning tools available. This enables the PPE to support creative thinking and NAF's unique business strategies, regardless of their complexity and how often the company may need to pivot in today's market.

Reflecting on her decision to adopt Polly's PPE, Kristin Ankeny Bickenbach, SVP of Secondary Marketing at New American Funding, said: "Back in the second half of last year, we knew the mortgage industry was in for a challenging 2023. I was asking myself: 'How can we maximize our responsiveness? How can we be creative and position ourselves for success in an incredibly challenging market?' As a sales-focused organization, I knew we needed a sharp PPE to enable us to act decisively and with precision, which is ultimately what led me to Polly."



Innovation at speed

Having rolled out Polly's PPE, NAF's team can now focus on developing new products and solutions without worrying about system limitations. Bickenbach added, "It's so refreshing to be able to take what's in my head and make it a reality. We have an amazingly creative secondary marketing team here at NAF, and with Polly, we can take our ideas and bring them to life."

NAF particularly appreciates Polly's approach to innovation, as well as the speed and agility of its development process. A pillar in Polly's customer-first culture, the team regularly consults its customer partners about upcoming features and product roadmap, taking care to act on this collaboration and direct feedback. As evidence of this, NAF continues to work closely with Polly's customer success, product, and executive teams, providing valuable insight and feedback on new innovations.

"We are honored to be working with New American Funding and take the trust that Kristin and the NAF team have put in Polly extremely seriously," explained Adam Carmel, Founder and CEO of Polly. "We are now consistently attracting huge players like NAF and I attribute this to two main factors. The first is the pedigree of our modern, cloud-native platform. Unencumbered by legacy technology, we can be agile and innovate quickly. The second is our unyielding dedication to long-term customer success. Customer-centricity is our superpower and will always remain a constant. We are excited to continue working with NAF and all our customer partners to push the boundaries of what is possible with mortgage technology."

Carmel continued: "We productize every idea in partnership with our customer partners, and the feedback they provide has created this sort of halo effect. We build it, and then in collaboration with our partners we take it to the next level. It just becomes this unbelievable flywheel."

> **With Polly, we can take our ideas and bring them to life.**

Putting borrowers first, while making life easier for LOs

Since its inception, NAF has put borrowers at the center of all its decisions, delivering an exceptional customer experience at all touchpoints. The company recognizes that this necessitates a modern, powerful, and intelligent technology infrastructure – an ethos it shares with Polly.

Bickenbach explained: "Given our vast product suite, we wanted to make it easier for LOs to match the best product to each individual borrower based on just a few simple questions. Thanks to Polly, we've created a single universe with our entire offering in one place – products we broker out, builder forwards, extended rate locks, lock and chop, bond programs, and much more. This enables us to deliver an even more borrower-centric experience."

Polly's usability and intuitiveness are also crucial to LO retention. With Polly, LOs can now easily match products to unique borrower goals (e.g., keeping monthly payments below a certain level or shortening mortgage terms). This not only guarantees the best borrower experience, but eliminates administrative work for LOs, freeing them up to focus on closing new deals and strengthening existing borrower relationships.

To ensure that NAF's LO team enjoyed a smooth transition, Polly delivered hands-on PPE training tailored to different users. Every persona across NAF's org was given dedicated time and attention during the onboarding process, which has only continued post implementation.

Building a partnership based on trust and open communication

The Polly team prides itself on a hands-on approach to customer service. This is key to its relationship with NAF. "It sounds cheesy, but every single member of Polly's team radiates passion and positivity," said Bickenbach. "Whether I am talking to the CEO or my account manager, we are all on a first-name basis and they know my business inside and out. Not only does this ensure that every communication we have is extremely efficient, but it creates an ideal environment for strategic discussions and ongoing implementation with a dedicated team. I feel that positive energy in every interaction, and really appreciate the hyper-personalized approach to customer service."

Bickenbach is also impressed at the speed with which Polly's team actions any changes requested by NAF: "Our solution is highly complex and personalized. When we want to make a change, the Polly team typically acts within hours. Polly's responsiveness and the way they have treated myself and my team as a customer gives me full confidence that they will be there to provide paramount support, even as our business continues to evolve."

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